

EE5203 L08 Study Sheet

PWM, output compare, and input capture - Basri Erdogan

Essential question: One register is called *capture/compare*. When you write it, the pin makes a waveform; when the pin makes a waveform, the hardware writes it. What decides which direction it runs?

What you should be able to do

- Explain PWM: frequency from ARR, duty from CCR.
- Choose PSC/ARR/CCR for a required frequency and duty from 16 MHz.
- Hand a pin to a timer and prove the handover in MODER.
- Configure direct and indirect capture channels and read the timestamps.
- Recover period, frequency, and duty from captures — wrap-safe.

One channel, two directions

GENERATING (output compare)	MEASURING (input capture)
you write CCR	the pin's edge triggers a snapshot
CNT counts up	CNT counts up
CNT < CCR -> output high	edge arrives -> CNT copied into CCR
CNT >= CCR -> output low	CC1IF set; you read CCR
CNT reaches ARR -> wrap	CNT free-runs to 0xFFFF and wraps

The direction bit is CC1S in CCMR1: 00 = output, non-zero = input. Same register file, same counter, opposite arrow.

Vocabulary table

Name	Job
CCR1...CCR4	compare value (you write) or captured timestamp (hardware writes)
CCMR1/2	CC1S direction, PWM mode, preload, input filter ICF
CCER	CC1E channel enable; CC1P output polarity / capture edge
CC1IF (SR)	a capture has landed
CC1OF (SR)	overcapture — a timestamp was overwritten before you read it
Direct mode	the channel listens to its own pin
Indirect mode	the channel listens to the <i>other</i> pin of the pair

PWM: the arithmetic

$$f_{\text{PWM}} = \frac{f_{\text{timer clock}}}{(\text{PSC} + 1)(\text{ARR} + 1)} \quad \text{duty} = \frac{\text{CCR}}{\text{ARR} + 1}$$

Requirement (16 MHz)	PSC	ARR	CCR	Result
1 kHz LED, 35 %	15	999	350	1 μ s tick, duty in tenths of a %
50 Hz servo, 1.5 ms	15	19999	1500	1 μ s tick — CCR is the pulse width in μ s
200 Hz, 25 %	15	4999	1250	

The 100 % subtlety. The counter visits ARR+1 states, so CCR = ARR gives ARR/(ARR+1) = 99.9 %, not full-on. True 100 % needs CCR > ARR.

One timer, one frequency. All four channels share PSC and ARR. A 1 kHz LED and a 50 Hz servo need two different timers.

The pin handover

```
HAL_TIM_PWM_Start(&htim2, TIM_CHANNEL_1);          /* enables CC1E */
__HAL_TIM_SET_COMPARE(&htim2, TIM_CHANNEL_1, 350); /* writes CCR1 */
```

CubeMX sets MODER bits for PA5 to 10 (alternate function) and selects AF1 for TIM2. Until that happens the pin still belongs to HAL_GPIO_WritePin and PWM does nothing visible — the classic silent failure.

Servo contract

Pulse width	Angle
1000 μ s	0°
1500 μ s	90°
2000 μ s	180°

```
uint16_t servo_us(uint8_t deg) {          /* 0-180 deg -> 1000-2000 us */
    if (deg > 180) deg = 180;              /* clamp: the contract is mechanical */
    return 1000 + (1000u * deg) / 180u;
}
```

Repeat every 20 ms. Pulses outside the contract strain the mechanism.

Capture: the arithmetic

```
/* rising edges, channel 1 direct */
uint16_t now = HAL_TIM_ReadCapturedValue(htim, TIM_CHANNEL_1);
period_us = (uint16_t)(now - last);      /* cast: wrap-safe on 16 bits */
last = now;

/* falling edge, channel 2 indirect - high time since the last rising edge */
high_us = (uint16_t)(HAL_TIM_ReadCapturedValue(htim, TIM_CHANNEL_2) - last);
```

$$f_{\text{signal}} = \frac{1}{\text{period}} \quad \text{duty} = \frac{\text{high_us}}{\text{period_us}}$$

- **The cast is not decoration.** On a 16-bit timer the subtraction must be done in 16 bits: captures 64000 then 1500 give $(\text{uint16_t})(1500 - 64000) = \mathbf{3036}$, the true elapsed count. Without the cast you get a large negative number.
- **Direct vs indirect.** CH1 direct listens to its own pin (TI1); CH2 indirect listens to TI1 as well, so both channels watch one signal on opposite edges. CH2 configured *direct* would listen to PB7 instead — and capture nothing.
- **Range.** A 16-bit timer at a 1 μ s tick measures honestly up to 65 536 μ s 65.5 ms, i.e. signals down to about **15.3 Hz**. Slower than that, the counter wraps more than once between edges and the number lies silently.

SFR evidence

Claim	Evidence
the duty is what you set	TIM2->CCR1 = 350; write 700 and the brightness steps
the pin belongs to the timer	MODER bits 11:10 = 10
the channel output is live	CCER bit 0 (CC1E) = 1; clearing it kills the output
hardware is timestamping	TIM4->CCR1 changes between pauses with no code running
the edge selection	CC1P in CCER; flip it and the captures move
a capture was lost	CC10F in TIM4->SR

Common mistakes

- Assuming 84 MHz from an online example — our board runs 16 MHz.
- Pin never handed over: MODER still 01.
- Confusing CCR and ARR: “changing the frequency” by writing CCR.
- Expecting CCR = ARR to be 100 %.
- One timer for two different frequencies.

- Subtraction not cast to `uint16_t`.
- CH2 left in direct mode, so duty comes out nonsense.
- `Start_IT` never called — configured, armed, but `CCR1` frozen.
- No input filter on a noisy line: every ring counts as an edge.

Mastery self-check

- ☐ I can derive `PSC/ARR/CCR` for a stated frequency and duty.
- ☐ I can explain why `CCR = ARR` is 99.9 %.
- ☐ I can state what `MODER` reads once a pin is handed to a timer.
- ☐ I can say who writes `CCR` in each direction, and when exactly.
- ☐ I can explain direct vs indirect and what each channel listens to.
- ☐ I can compute period and duty from two or three captures, wrap-safe.
- ☐ I can state the slowest signal a 16-bit timer measures at a 1 μ s tick.
- ☐ I can name the flag that tells me a capture was lost.

Five review questions

1. From 16 MHz, give `PSC/ARR/CCR` for a 2 kHz PWM at 60 %. Then say what changes if the requirement becomes 2 kHz at 60 % **on a servo timer already running at 50 Hz** — and why.
2. A student sets `CCR = 1000` with `ARR = 999` expecting 100 %, and reports the LED is full-on. Are they right? Explain what the comparison does.
3. Your PWM code is correct and the LED does not dim, but `HAL_GPIO_WritePin` still controls it. Name the register and the exact value you would check.
4. Captures on a 16-bit, 1 μ s timer arrive at 64000 then 1500. Compute the period two ways — with and without the `uint16_t` cast — and explain the difference in terms of modular arithmetic.
5. You measure a 10 Hz signal with a 16-bit timer at a 1 μ s tick and get a plausible-looking but wrong period. Explain the failure and give two different fixes.

See the L08 worksheet for extended practice. Worked solutions are released after the practice window.